

“The theory is young and **treated with suspicion.**”

Alfred Wegener, 1915

of western Africa and eastern South America mirrored each other, like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle, and he wondered if they had once been joined together. In fact, he wondered if all of the Earth's continents had once been linked. He was not the first to notice the Africa–America pattern: it had been observed as early as the 16th century, and discoveries in the 19th century of the same types of fossils in both places had also attracted attention. Previous explanations included that the continents had been separated by the biblical Flood or that they were once joined by land bridges that had since sunk into the sea.

Continental drift

Wegener dug deeper, searching in different scientific fields for more evidence. In the fossil record, he found further examples of the same species on different continents and discovered the same ancient rock formations on the African and South American coasts. He also found fragments of an ancient mountain range on unconnected

250 MILLION YEARS AGO



Cynognathus was a large doglike reptile that lived around 250 million years ago. Its fossils were found in both South Africa and South America.

continents and glacial deposits at the equator. All of this supported the idea that the continents had moved.

In 1912, Wegener presented his theory of continental drift, proposing that the continents had once been a single land mass, or “supercontinent,” which he called Pangea. However, his idea was not well received. Geologists dismissed him for being an amateur